ON MARCH 10, WHEN THE counting of ballots began at 8am at the government polytechnic in Altinho in Panaji, Goa, the mood was somber. Just two hours later, though, the atmosphere had turned jubilant as BJP workers garlanded a victorious Vishwajit Rane and hoisted him on their shoulders to chants of "CM Vishwajit Rane *yancha vijay aso* (cheers to CM Vishwajit Rane)". The health minister in the Pramod Sawant government could barely conceal his grin, but was humble in his response. "I have no ambition to become the chief minister. I will abide by the decision taken by my party leaders," he told reporters.

The BJP office turned celebratory once again after the news of Sawant's victory came in. The workers cheered: "Pramod Sawant once more". And though the CM's victory margin was 756, his thinnest so far over the past three elections, it diminished Rane's chances of landing the top post.

The support for Rane, though, is a sign of the new BJP in Goa. The Ranes of Sattari, erstwhile royals, had traditionally been Congress loyalists, but Vishwajit Rane, son of six-time CM Pratapsingh Rane, chose to throw in his lot with the winning side after the election results were announced in March 2017. He was rewarded with a cabinet post while retaining Valpoi, a Rane stronghold.

The BJP's gamble of fielding 33 defectors seems to have paid off in thwarting anti-incumbency. The Sawant government had been facing a lot of dissent over allegations of corruption during the pandemic, attempts to turn the state into a coal transportation hub and disregard for the environment, among other things. It was the defectors, mostly local strongmen, who managed to retain their traditional vote bank and helped the BJP win 20 of the state's 40 seats, one short of the majority mark of 21.

For one, the BJP managed to retain its north Goa stronghold, winning 11 of the region's 20 seats. The OBC (other backward classes) voters, who have traditionally supported the BJP, came to the party's rescue again. The BJP's win is also impressive given that one of its more influential leaders, Michael Lobo, had joined the Congress just days before the poll and used his influence and financial clout to campaign extensively against his former party. Lobo managed to damage the BJP's prospects in Calangute, Saligao and Siolim, but could not wipe them out in north Goa as he had vowed to do. The BJP's decision to induct independent MLA Rohan Khaunte and GFP (Goa Forward Party) MLA Jayesh Salgaonkar also helped negate Lobo's influence. Similarly, the BJP-engineered coup within the Rane family helped it conquer the Congress stronghold of Poriem. Vishwajit Rane's wife Deviya was persuaded to contest the seat on a BJP ticket, delivering the constituency that her father-in-law had nurtured for over 50 years. The senior Rane, a Congressman, did not contest the election to avoid a feud in the family.

That outsiders will form the core of the BJP in the future was evident even in Atanasio Monserrate's victory in Panaji, where he was pitted against Manohar Parrikar's son Utpal. Monserrate managed to upend the Parrikar legacy only three years after the BJP stalwart's death in March 2019. True to his nature, though, he refused to acknowledge that the BJP had anything to do with his and his wife Jennifer's wins. "The BJP workers did not work for us," he told INDIA TODAY. "We have won because of our people." Monserrate, however, has said he would remain in the BJP till his last breath. A criminal case against him pertaining to a 2008 attack on a Panaji police station could be the driving force behind this loyalty.

The BJP also performed impressively in its 'weak' region—south Goa. It won nine of its 20 seats, its highest tally in the region since 2012, despite dissent among Catholic voters and the BJP's poor organ-

